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A qualitative study of academic perspectives on AI

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Abstract. *The growing use of AI-based text generation tools such as ChatGPT is reshaping academic practices and raising new questions about academic integrity. As higher education institutions grapple with policy, pedagogy, and ethical boundaries, students and teachers are left navigating unclear expectations. This thesis explores how Swedish university students and teachers perceive generative AI's impact on academic integrity, particularly concerning plagiarism and responsible use. A targeted concept-centric literature review was conducted to map existing research on AI in education, academic ethics, and evolving pedagogical responses. The findings reveal conflicting perspectives, conceptual ambiguity, and a lack of empirical insight into how academic communities engage with these tools. The thesis applies a qualitative research design to address this gap, using purposive sampling and semi-structured interviews with students and teachers across disciplines. Thematic analysis identifies six themes: informal norms, ethical uncertainty, and shifting perceptions of authorship. The findings show how academic norms are being renegotiated in practice and may support the development of clearer institutional strategies and ethical frameworks for AI use in higher education.*

Key words: Academic integrity, Generative AI, Students and teachers, Plagiarism, Higher education

1 Introduction

Integrating generative AI into higher education has prompted a shift in how academic work is created, assessed, and understood. Tools such as ChatGPT have introduced new possibilities for support in academic writing, but have also raised questions about authorship, learning, and academic integrity. As these technologies become increasingly accessible, institutions and individuals are grappling with how to navigate their use responsibly. While AI in education has long been a topic of interest, the recent emergence of powerful language models represents a fundamental disruption to established pedagogical practices (Miao et al., 2021; Chiu, 2024; Hasan et al., 2020; Smutny & Schreiberova, 2020; Bobula, 2024).

Students are now using AI tools not just to assist with spelling or grammar but to generate content, brainstorm ideas, or even complete entire assignments. Although these uses may offer practical benefits, they also introduce ambiguity about what constitutes original work and what role human effort should play in learning (Evangelista, 2025; Meyer et al., 2023). At the same time, teachers face the challenge of assessing work that may have been produced in collaboration with AI tools without clear institutional guidance on what counts as acceptable support or academic misconduct (Dempere et al., 2023; López-Pérez et al., 2023; Ogunleye et al., 2024). These tensions highlight a growing need to rethink the definitions of integrity, originality, and authorship in the context of AI-augmented learning (Schlagwein & Willcocks, 2023; Lo, 2023; Floridi & Chiriatti, 2020; Dwivedi et al., 2023). Despite the rapid spread of generative AI in higher education, current research is often limited to policy analysis, technical perspectives, or theoretical discussions. There is still a lack of empirical insight into how students and teachers experience these tools in practice, especially across different academic disciplines. While some studies have examined institutional responses or pedagogical strategies (e.g., Söderström et al., 2024; Kamalov et al., 2023), fewer have explored the lived experiences of academic communities navigating these changes in real-time. Questions remain about how informal norms are developing in the absence of clear policy and how ethical concerns are being interpreted in everyday academic work (Meyer et al., 2023; Farrokhnia et al., 2023; Börekci & Çelik, 2024). Understanding these experiences is crucial for shaping institutional responses grounded in reality rather than assumption.

To address this gap, this thesis investigates how students and teachers in Swedish universities perceive the impact of AI-based text generation tools on academic integrity, particularly concerning plagiarism and ethical practices. The aim is twofold: first, to understand how academic norms are being challenged, negotiated, and redefined in an AI environment, and second, to offer insight into how universities might better support responsible AI use in education. This study focuses on various academic disciplines and prioritises the voices of those directly engaging with generative AI in their studies or teaching. The focus is twofold: first, to explore how students and teachers experience the challenges, negotiations, and redefinitions of academic norms, and second, to offer insight into how universities might better support responsible AI use in education. The study draws from academic disciplines and includes student and teacher perspectives to reflect varied engagements with generative AI.

The following question guides the research:
How do students and teachers in Swedish universities perceive the impact of AI-based text generation tools on academic integrity, particularly in relation to plagiarism and ethical practices?

The study adopts a qualitative research design to answer this question, combining a targeted concept-centric literature review with semi-structured interviews. The literature review explores academic integrity, authorship, and institutional responses to AI tools, while the empirical data provides a grounded understanding of how these issues manifest in everyday academic contexts. Thematic analysis is used to identify key patterns across the interviews, following the framework of Braun and Clarke (2006). This thesis contributes to a growing body of research on AI's ethical and pedagogical educational challenges by drawing on theoretical and empirical perspectives. The findings may inform future policy development, institutional practices, and teaching strategies to balance innovation with integrity. In particular, the study responds to calls for more research that captures diverse perspectives and recognises the complexity of responsible AI use in educational settings (Miao et al., 2021; Dempere et al., 2023; Evangelista, 2025).

The thesis is structured as follows. Chapter 2 presents the literature review, outlining existing research on AI in education, academic integrity, and institutional adaptation. Chapter 3 details the methodology, including the research design, participant selection, and analytical approach. Chapter 4 reports the findings and thematic analysis of the interview data. Chapter 5 discusses the results concerning existing literature and theoretical frameworks. Finally, Chapter 6 concludes with reflections on the study’s contributions and limitations.

2 Literature review

This chapter presents findings from a targeted literature review exploring academic perspectives on AI-based text generation tools and their connection to academic integrity. The review identifies key themes and conceptual debates in the literature, focusing on plagiarism, ethical concerns, and evolving educational practices.

2.1 AI in education: Evolution and applications

Artificial intelligence (AI) integration into education has progressed through distinct phases, evolving from early systems to tools shaping modern pedagogy. Panda (2024) outlines this process, beginning with the 1960s platforms like PLATO, through the rise of intelligent tutoring systems in the 1980s and 1990s, and then moving to machine learning-based tools in the 2000s that supported real-time adaptation. These developments show a shift from experimental systems to integrated educational tools. Across the literature, a consistent theme is AI’s ability to restructure teaching roles and processes. Chen et al. (2020) highlight how automated grading and scheduling free educators to focus more on pedagogy, which has created a shift that allows educators to spend more time developing engaging lesson plans and creating meaningful interactions with students. Volante et al. (2023) note that analytics-driven tools help teachers personalise learning, reinforcing the transition from content deliverers to facilitators. Educators can use these tools to support students’ needs better and create improved engagement with the material. In a UNESCO policy report, Miao et al. (2021) distinguish between student-, teacher-, and system-facing AI tools, noting that early innovation often focused on student-facing systems designed to simulate one-on-one instruction. This classification shows how AI use differs based on teaching goals and user roles, expanding how AI in education is understood.

Hasan et al. (2020) further highlight how AI-based video learning analytics can predict student performance and enhance educational planning. Their study underscores the value of combining user data with adaptive systems to support decision-making in higher education. A growing body of research focuses on student-facing generative AI, such as chatbots and recommendation systems. These tools personalise feedback, encourage autonomous learning, and introduce tensions around dependency, authority, and academic standards. While often framed as enablers, their more serious implications prompt debate on educational values and control.

The emergence of tools like ChatGPT signals a shift from AI as a support tool to AI as a co-creator. Chiu (2024) argues that generative AI challenges traditional ideas of authorship and assessment, blurring the line between assistance and replacement. This blurred boundary raises broader concerns about academic authenticity and learning. Building on this, Smutny and Schreiberova (2020) argue that educational AI must be evaluated for its technical effectiveness and pedagogical and ethical alignment. Their review of chatbot applications in education shows that while such tools can enhance learning, their value depends heavily on how they are contextualised within the learning environment. Institutional responses to generative AI are increasingly urgent. Dempere et al. (2023) observe that while these tools support teaching and assessment, they also raise concerns about plagiarism, data privacy, and misinformation. In response, universities update honour codes, adjust courses, and issue policy guidelines.

Dempere et al. (2023), referencing UNESCO guidance, have called for regulation based on transparency, equity, and ethical practice. This call for regulation marks a shift from experimentation to institutional reflection. It raises an important question: What does it mean to teach in a world where AI can act as co-author and teacher? Rather than resisting generative AI, the literature calls for strategic adoption guided by critical pedagogy and responsive control (Dempere et al., 2023).

2.2 Ethical concerns and academic integrity

The introduction of generative AI tools such as ChatGPT has prompted renewed debate around academic integrity. While offering benefits like personalised support and increased accessibility, these tools raise ethical concerns, particularly around plagiarism and cheating. ChatGPT enables students to submit work with minimal effort, often evading traditional plagiarism detection systems. Cotton et al. (2023) and Evangelista (2025) warn that such use undermines learning by allowing students to skip critical thinking and engagement. Detection is still a significant challenge. AI-generated content is typically unique and fluent, making it difficult to flag using standard text-matching tools. Meyer et al. (2023) highlight that while some indicators of AI-generated content, such as fabricated references or overly vague responses, can emerge, they are often hard to detect. This challenge has raised concerns about fairness and led to calls for better guidelines and tools. The literature also highlights a broader loss of learning integrity. As Evangelista (2025) notes, students increasingly rely on AI to generate content instead of developing academic skills. This overreliance changes responsibility from the student to the tool, raising concerns about ethics and educational value. Authorship and misrepresentation are also under examination. Schlagwein and Willcocks (2023) argue that while AI should not be considered an author, users are responsible for disclosing their role.

Meyer et al. (2023) suggest that undisclosed AI use, even if the text is "original," should be considered a new form of plagiarism. Also, Floridi and Chiriatti (2020) argue that generative AI tools like GPT-3 create outputs without understanding or intentionality, raising intellectual and ethical challenges when students present their content as authored**.** The literature urges a rethinking of how academic ownership is defined in the AI era. Beyond individual behaviour, AI tools also pose risks through misinformation and bias. ChatGPT can produce inaccurate or fabricated claims, which, if unchecked, may undermine academic discourse (Meyer et al., 2023). Biases embedded in training data also risk reinforcing stereotypes in educational contexts. Findings by Dwivedi et al. (2023) further stress that the speed of generative AI adoption is outpacing the development of institutional safeguards, prompting urgent questions about regulatory standards and ethical literacy among students and educators. Transparency and accountability have become significant concerns. Institutions increasingly expect students and researchers to acknowledge AI assistance, but enforcement remains inconsistent. Disclosure is essential for evaluating the validity of work and maintaining trust in scholarly communication.

Rather than advocating absolute restrictions, recent studies call for a balanced approach to AI integration. When used transparently and under guidance, AI can enhance learning without compromising academic values. Miao et al. (2021) emphasise the need for ethically grounded strategies that position AI as a complement to, rather than a replacement for, human intelligence.

2.3 Institutional and pedagogical strategies for the AI era

The rapid rise of generative AI in higher education has prompted various institutional and pedagogical responses, reflecting both caution and opportunity. The literature highlights an ongoing shift in how educators and institutions approach academic integrity, assessment design, and policy development. A key concern is how institutions update academic policies to respond to AI. Dempere et al. (2023), referencing UNESCO guidance, note that universities are issuing more straightforward guidelines on permissible AI use and increasingly requiring disclosure of AI assistance in coursework. Evangelista (2025) observes that many institutions have continually formed working groups to modify academic integrity policies. These efforts aim to balance enforcement with education, ensuring students understand the rules and the rationale behind them. Educators, in turn, are adapting their teaching methods. Söderström et al. (2024) found that many university teachers in Sweden expressed both interest and uncertainty about integrating AI tools like ChatGPT into their teaching. A lack of institutional support and clear national guidelines has led to varied responses, with some educators adjusting exams and assignments pre-emptively and others warning students without formal strategies. A systematic review by López-Pérez et al. (2023) emphasises the need for comprehensive institutional policies and professional development to guide educators in effectively integrating AI tools into their teaching practices. The need for professional development and administrative backing is widely emphasised.

The most visible pedagogical response has been a shift in assessment design. As Evangelista (2025) writes, institutions such as Stanford and the University of Sydney have begun redesigning assessments to reduce dependency on take-home essays and instead emphasise in-class writing, oral exams, applied projects, and group work. These formats prioritise higher-order thinking, personal reflection, and live performance, where AI assistance is limited. These adjustments are intended to protect academic integrity while supporting improved learning outcomes. At the same time, some educators are exploring ways to use AI as a teaching tool. Examples include allowing students to draft with AI and then critically evaluate the output or prompting students to revise AI-generated text as part of an exercise in digital literacy (Evangelista, 2025). Ogunleye et al. (2024) discuss how integrating AI into coursework can enhance students' critical thinking and ethical reflection when assignments are explicitly designed to engage with AI output rather than bypass it. These strategies reflect a growing awareness that a total ban on AI may be counterproductive and may overlook opportunities to help students develop evaluative and ethical thinking. Debates continue around the extent to which AI should be embraced or limited. Söderström et al. (2024) note that while some educators see AI as a valuable study aid, others worry about the erosion of skills and unfair advantages. Evangelista (2025) captures this tension, with some universities temporarily restricting AI tools to preserve assessment credibility while others shift toward guided integration. Across the literature, an increasing agreement supports a balanced approach that leverages AI's potential while maintaining clear boundaries and reinforcing academic values. Successful adaptation depends on a combination of strategies: updating assessment formats, developing clear and enforceable policies, supporting teachers through training, and equipping students with the skills to engage with AI responsibly. Institutions are increasingly treating AI not as a passing trend but as a permanent feature of the academic environment that requires ongoing reflection and responsive governance.

2.4 Challenges and research gaps

Despite the growing literature on generative AI in education, several challenges and unresolved questions remain. While the previous sections explored current perspectives on AI tools and academic integrity, this section highlights ongoing tensions and limitations in practice and research. These challenges reflect the complexity of integrating AI tools into academic settings and current studies' limitations in addressing how students and teachers understand and use such tools. A central issue concerns the evolving definition of plagiarism and authorship. Some scholars argue that AI-generated content does not meet traditional definitions of plagiarism since it is not copied from a human source (Meyer et al., 2023). Others stress that submitting AI-generated work without disclosure undermines the core academic value of intellectual responsibility (Schlagwein & Willcocks, 2023; Evangelista, 2025). The absence of a consistent definition leaves both educators and students without clear ethical boundaries, while institutional policies frequently lag behind these conceptual developments (Dempere et al., 2023). There is also a lack of agreement on what constitutes acceptable AI use in academic contexts. Söderström et al. (2024) found that educators view tools like ChatGPT with ambivalence: some see the potential for enhancing accessibility and engagement, while others worry that such tools reduce the need for critical thinking and independent learning.

Kamalov et al. (2023) and Farrokhnia et al. (2023) warn of overreliance, suggesting that AI tools may weaken students' academic autonomy and long-term skill development. Echoing this concern, Börekci and Çelik (2024) identify a persistent gap in student digital literacy, arguing that institutions must address this imbalance to ensure the ethical and practical use of generative AI tools in academic settings. These theoretical tensions have practical consequences for teaching decisions and classroom policy (Evangelista, 2025; Lo, 2023).

Institutional responses to AI have likewise been inconsistent. While some universities have adopted restrictive policies to protect assessment integrity (Evangelista, 2025), others are beginning to integrate AI into coursework by establishing transparency and disclosure guidelines (Dempere et al., 2023; Miao et al., 2021). Still, many educators report feeling unprepared due to limited professional development and unclear national guidance (Söderström et al., 2024). This inconsistency has led to varied and sometimes conflicting practices across institutions.

Technological limitations further complicate efforts to maintain academic standards. Traditional plagiarism detection tools often fail to recognise AI-generated content, and newer AI-detection systems show mixed reliability (Meyer et al., 2023; Chiu, 2024). Relying on these tools introduces fairness and due process concerns, particularly when false positives may unfairly penalise students (Evangelista, 2025; Van den Berg & du Plessis, 2023).

Detection technologies do little to address how learning outcomes can be preserved in environments where AI is routinely used. Bobula (2024) further notes that educators often face a dilemma between embracing AI-driven innovation and protecting the pedagogical foundations of academic integrity, which has yet to be resolved by policy frameworks. Beneath these concerns lies a broader philosophical tension between the desire to innovate and the imperative to uphold academic integrity. While some argue for embracing AI as a tool for personalised learning, digital literacy, and pedagogical support (Miao et al., 2021; Söderström et al., 2024), others urge caution, citing risks related to fairness, misinformation, and bias (Meyer et al., 2023; Lo, 2023). These differing perspectives point to a need for clearer frameworks that guide both institutional policy and day-to-day academic practice. While many of these tensions are acknowledged in the literature, there remains a notable lack of qualitative research exploring how students and teachers experience and interpret these challenges in practice. Much of the existing research focuses on policy, institutional strategy, or conceptual analysis, with relatively few studies capturing the lived experiences of those directly engaging with AI in education. Few studies have directly compared student and teacher perspectives on AI-generated text despite the likelihood that their roles and concerns differ significantly.

To address these gaps, this thesis investigates how students and teachers in Swedish universities perceive and respond to the impact of AI-based text-generation tools on academic integrity. By focusing on their experiences, the study aims to contribute new insight into a rapidly evolving and under-theorised academic landscape and to lay the foundation for more informed and inclusive responses within higher education.

3 Method

3.1 Research design

To answer the research question, How do students and teachers in Swedish universities perceive the impact of AI-based text generation tools on academic integrity, particularly in relation to plagiarism and ethical practices? This thesis adopted a qualitative research design involving two main components: a targeted literature review and semi-structured interviews.

The literature review used a concept-centric approach (Webster & Watson, 2002) and was thematically analysed following Braun and Clarke's (2006) principles. The review informed the development of the interview guide and identified key themes and gaps in the existing discourse.

The interviews were designed and conducted to provide empirical insight into the ethical concerns, practical uses, and academic responses to AI tools such as ChatGPT. The collected data were coded and analysed using thematic analysis to identify patterns and develop a deeper understanding of participants' perspectives. This qualitative design was chosen to ensure that the study remained grounded in prior research while generating new insight through the systematic analysis of empirical data.

Interviews were selected as the primary method because they were well-suited for exploring complex experiences, personal interpretations, and ethical considerations that cannot easily be captured through surveys or quantitative measures. This approach allowed for collecting in-depth perspectives, which was especially valuable when addressing a rapidly evolving and nuanced topic such as AI in education.

3.2 Literature review design

A targeted literature review explored current perspectives and research gaps concerning AI-based text generation tools and academic integrity in higher education. The review followed the concept-centric approach proposed by Webster and Watson (2002), which focuses on creating themes across studies rather than presenting findings by author or in chronological order. This structure supported the identification of dominant narratives and underexplored issues directly relevant to the research question.

Peer-reviewed articles were retrieved using Google Scholar and Scopus, focusing on literature published from 2020 onward to mirror the recent development and adoption of tools such as ChatGPT. Search terms included combinations of *AI tools*, *ChatGPT*, *plagiarism*, *academic integrity*, *higher education*, *students*, *teachers*, *generative AI*, *ethics in education*, *assessment*, *learning*, and *institutional policy*. The selection process involved reviewing titles and abstracts, followed by introductions and conclusions. Full texts were read when relevance to the study's aims was confirmed.

The selected literature was analysed thematically using Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-phase framework. While initially designed for qualitative data, the model was applied to identify patterns and recurring themes across the literature.
This analytical process informed the structure of the literature review (Chapter 2) and directly shaped the design of the semi-structured interview guide used in the empirical phase.

3.3 Interview design

An interview guide was developed based on themes from the literature review, ensuring that the interview structure remained grounded in current academic discourse. Semi-structured interviews allowed flexibility in the order and phrasing of questions and the opportunity to follow up on interesting points raised by participants (Bryman, 2018).

The structure and ethical considerations of the interviews followed recommendations by Bryman (2018) for designing and conducting semi-structured interviews in qualitative research. This ensured coherence between the theoretical and empirical components of the study. Table 1 outlines the design used in this thesis based on those principles.

The complete interview guide is included in Appendix 1.

Interview planning considerations (Bryman, 2018)	**Planned application**
Interview format	Semi-structured individual interviews
Purpose of the method	Explore participants' perception of AI-generated text in academic settings.

Development of questions	Based on themes identified through the literature review
Interview structure and flexibility	A guide will be used, with the flexibility to adjust question order and include follow-ups.
Duration	Approximately 30-45 minutes per interview
Data recording	Interviews will be audio recorded with consent; field notes will be taken.
Ethical considerations	Informed consent, confidentiality, and voluntary participation will be ensured.

Table 1: Interview planning using Bryman (2018)

3.4 Participant recruitment and selection

Participants included both students and teachers from Swedish universities. A purposive sampling strategy was employed to recruit individuals with relevant experience in academic writing, assessment, or teaching. This approach enabled the selection of participants who were knowledgeable about the research topic and were likely to contribute rich and relevant data (Bryman, 2018; Palinkas et al., 2015).

For student participants, the inclusion criteria required individuals to be currently enrolled in higher education in Sweden and to have experience using AI-based text generation tools, such as ChatGPT, in an academic context. Students were recruited from at least two to three academic disciplines to explore how reliance on such tools might differ across subject areas.

Teacher participants were required to be actively teaching at a Swedish university or university college and to have experience encountering or using generative AI tools in teaching, assessment, or course design. This could include assessing AI-generated work, adapting assignments in response to AI, or integrating AI into teaching practices.

Participants were selected across programme levels and institutions to ensure a diverse and balanced dataset. Recruitment was conducted through university mailing lists, academic networks, and direct outreach to faculty members and student organisations.

The initial target was to recruit approximately 5 to 10 participants per group (students and teachers) to continue recruitment until data saturation. However, this goal was only partially met. Recruiting teachers proved relatively straightforward through professional outreach, although many candidates cited time constraints. One teacher per faculty was considered sufficient to provide variation in perspective and contribute to thematic coverage. In contrast, student recruitment posed more significant challenges. Despite efforts to recruit ethically through official university channels, many students either declined or did not respond. This limited the final sample size and may have prevented full saturation among student participants. Nevertheless, the dataset yielded rich and relevant insights from all included participants.

The final sample consisted of nine students and four teachers from three faculties.

While the final sample did not meet the initial numeric targets, it was sufficient to enable meaningful cross-role and cross-disciplinary comparisons within the scope of this thesis.
An overview of the participants is presented in Table 2.

Participant	Role	Faculty
Student 1	Student	Informatics
Student 2	Student	Informatics
Student 3	Student	Informatics
Student 4	Student	Informatics
Student 5	Student	Informatics
Student 6	Student	Education, Humanities and Social Sciences
Student 7	Student	Education, Humanities and Social Sciences
Student 8	Student	Health and welfare
Student 9	Student	Health and welfare
Teacher A	Teacher	Informatics
Teacher B	Teacher	Informatics
Teacher C	Teacher	Education, humanities and social sciences
Teacher D	Teacher	Health and Welfare

Table 2: Interview participants

3.5 Data collection and analysis plan

Interviews were recorded with consent and transcribed word-for-word. The data were analysed using a thematic analysis based on the six-phase framework developed by Braun and Clarke (2006). This approach was well-suited for identifying meaningful patterns within qualitative data and allowed the researcher to remain closely involved in understanding participants' perspectives.

The analysis process followed two main steps:

• **Initial coding and theme generation**: The analysis began with familiarising the transcripts through repeated reading, noting early observations and recurring points of interest. From there, initial codes were generated manually, highlighting relevant features across the dataset, particularly those related to academic integrity, reliance on AI, and ethical practices. These codes were then grouped to begin identifying and constructing potential themes.

• **Theme refinement and reporting**: Once provisional themes were formed, they were reviewed and refined for internal consistency and relevance to the research question. Each theme was clearly defined and named to represent its conceptual focus. The thesis integrated these themes into a narrative supported by illustrative quotes, and the analysis was placed within the literature.

In line with Braun and Clarke (2006), all coding was conducted manually to encourage close engagement with the data. An iterative approach was used, with citations copied into Microsoft Word or Excel and labelled using descriptive codes. Visual mapping tools such as Miro or Figma supported the organisation and interpretation of emerging themes. This process ensured a transparent and flexible analytical structure grounded in the empirical material.
This process resulted in six main themes, forming the basis for the findings and discussion in Chapter 5.

The analysed data was the foundation for identifying key concerns and strategies for academic integrity in generative AI. These findings were then critically discussed in relation to the existing literature in Chapter 5.

3.6 Ethical considerations

This study followed the ethical principles outlined by Bryman (2018), which include four key requirements:

• **The information requirement**: Participants were informed about the study's purpose, how their data would be used, and their rights as participants. Brief information regarding this was provided before each interview.

• **The consent requirement**: Informed consent was obtained in writing. Participation was voluntary, and participants could withdraw without explanation or consequence.

• **The confidentiality requirement**: All participants were kept anonymous. No personal identifiers were collected, and pseudonyms (e.g., “Student A” and “Teacher 1”) were used in all documentation and reporting.

• **The utilisation requirement**: Data were used solely for this thesis and were not shared or reused. After completing the thesis, all recordings and transcripts were securely stored and deleted.

Participants received clear written and verbal information about the study, including its purpose, what their participation involved, and how their contributions would be used.
They were also informed that interviews would be audio-recorded for transcription and analysis.

Before giving consent, participants could ask questions or raise concerns. Written consent was collected before participation, and all participants were reminded of their right to withdraw at any stage. The interview data were used exclusively for this thesis and handled according to confidentiality and ethical principles.

The participant materials, included in Appendix 2 and Appendix 3, were developed by established ethical practices in qualitative research and the principles outlined by Bryman (2018).

3.7 Method discussion

The methodological design of this thesis was grounded in a qualitative, interpretive approach to explore how AI-based text generation tools are understood, experienced, and negotiated by students and teachers within Swedish higher education. Integrating a concept-centric literature review with semi-structured interviews provided a theoretical and empirical foundation for an in-depth examination of these perspectives.

Semi-structured interviews were well suited for accessing complex reasoning, personal experience, and ethical reflection. These were essential elements in understanding how individuals interpret the role of generative AI in educational settings. This form of interviewing allowed flexibility in structure and delivery, supporting a more natural and open conversation between researcher and participant. The interview guide was developed through an iterative process grounded in themes identified during the literature review, ensuring theoretical coherence. Combining literature review and interviews benefited the study by providing more in-depth data relevant to the research field. Conducting interviews without a foundation in current research would have risked producing questions that lack relevance. Basing the interviews on the literature also supported participant engagement by establishing trust and minimising disinterest. The topic of AI and academia is particularly well suited to this approach, as both areas are continuously evolving. These modifications need to be considered to avoid overlooking critical developments.

A goal-directed sampling strategy ensured participants were familiar with the studied topic through direct experience or professional engagement. This enhanced the potential for obtaining rich and relevant data. This approach also presented challenges in terms of generalisation, as the study focused on specific educational settings and perspectives.

Thematic analysis was selected as the analytic approach due to its flexibility and clarity in identifying patterns across qualitative data. Braun and Clarke's (2006) framework provided a robust structure for this process while allowing the researcher to remain interpretively active throughout. The decision to code manually using Word or Excel reflected a preference for close, iterative engagement with the data and supported complete transparency in theme development.

While this thesis does not offer a formalised framework, it contributes empirical insight that may inform future institutional strategies or guidelines. These findings highlight how AI-related practices and values are negotiated without shared norms. A summary of these findings is presented in Table 3.

4 Findings and Analysis

This chapter presents the key themes from a thematic analysis of interviews with students and teachers from a Swedish university's three faculties. In total, 13 participants were interviewed, including nine students and four teachers representing the fields of informatics, education, social sciences, and health and welfare. An overview of the participants is provided in Table 2.

The chapter is organised thematically and draws on student and teacher perspectives to explore how AI-based text-generation tools are perceived concerning academic integrity. Each section highlights a central theme supported by illustrative quotes, offering insight into how academic norms, practices, and responsibilities are being interpreted and negotiated in light of generative AI.

4.1 Navigating responsible AI use

Across the interviews, students and teachers stressed the importance of using AI tools with care and intention. Participants were not categorically against AI use but described a variety of personal boundaries, routines, and values that guided their decisions. A common thread was that AI should support the academic process, not replace it. This theme highlights how informants think critically about when and how to use tools like ChatGPT, often without clear rules from the school.

Several students described strategies for limiting their reliance on AI tools to preserve the integrity of their thinking. Some emphasised using ChatGPT primarily to structure thoughts or generate ideas, followed by substantial rewriting in their own words. Others noted that overuse of AI, especially early in the writing process, made them feel disconnected from the assignment.

> *"I usually just use it to get inspiration or for structure. If I ask for something, I always rewrite it in my own words. It doesn't feel right to hand in something it wrote." Student 3*

Others viewed the tool as a helpful supplement, particularly when struggling with time pressure or mental fatigue. Even so, they remained aware of the risk of over-dependence and often mentioned consciously trying to maintain a balance.

> *"When I'm tired or just not getting started, I sometimes ask it to write something, and then I use that to get going. But I don't copy it. I still want it to be mine." Student 6*

Less discussion was given on responsible use regarding personal strategies among teachers, and more about how students might engage with the tool. There was a shared sense of cautious acceptance, with some teachers encouraging students to use AI critically and reflectively. Others highlighted that without proper guidance, students risk bypassing key aspects of learning.

> *"I don't mind if students use it, but I want them to think about how they're using it. Are they just letting the tool do the work, or are they learning something from the process?" Teacher 1*

This theme shows that across participants, there is a shared concern about the fine line between using AI as a support and letting it take over. The participants accepted AI but approached it with a strong sense of responsibility and a desire to preserve learning and originality.

4.2 Perceptions of academic integrity in the AI era

A widespread concern across the interviews was how AI tools like ChatGPT influence students' and teachers' understanding of academic integrity. Participants consistently linked integrity to effort, transparency, and originality, though their interpretations varied. Rather than defining integrity only concerning rules or policies, many described it as a personal responsibility or internal compass guiding their academic behaviour.

Students often reflected on how AI affected their sense of ownership and authenticity. Some felt that using AI too early in the writing process made it harder to call the work their own, even if they revised it heavily.

> *"If I start with ChatGPT too early, it feels like it becomes the one doing the thinking, and then I just follow. That's not really my work anymore." Student 5*

Others pointed out that academic integrity is about avoiding plagiarism and demonstrating genuine engagement with learning. Using AI for support was acceptable, but only when students actively shaped the final result.

> *"You still have to put in your own thought. Even if you use it a little, what matters is if you're just copying or actually thinking about what you're doing." Student 4*

Teachers expressed similar values, though with additional concern about detection and boundaries. One teacher noted that the difficulty of identifying AI-generated content complicated assessment and raised new ethical dilemmas for educators.

> *"It's hard to know what's written by a student and what isn't. If we can't tell, how can we really assess learning or originality?" Teacher 3*

There was also concern that institutional definitions of plagiarism and authorship were not keeping pace with the changes introduced by generative AI. Some teachers expressed uncertainty about what should be considered misconduct in this new context.

> *"We need to rethink what plagiarism means. If a student rewrites AI-generated content in their own words, is that cheating? It's not clear to me." Teacher 4*

This theme highlights that while participants still value traditional academic principles, generative AI has introduced a layer of ambiguity into what those principles mean in practice. Both groups desired more precise boundaries and shared definitions, but many relied on their judgment in the absence of those.

4.3 Institutional uncertainty and informal norms

Across the interviews, students and teachers indicated a lack of clear institutional guidance regarding AI-based text-generation tools. This uncertainty had led to a patchwork of informal rules and personal interpretations, often shaped by classmates' practices, individual teacher expectations, or trial and error.

Several students noted that they had not received explicit guidance from their university or programme on whether or how tools like ChatGPT could be used in academic work. This absence of policy left them unsure of what was acceptable, resulting in hesitation or inconsistency in their approach.

> *"No one's really told us what's okay or not. Some teachers are fine with it, others don't even bring it up. So, you sort of figure it out yourself." Student 2*

In the absence of formal rules, students described relying on cues from their surroundings, such as group discussions or teacher attitudes. This led to the formation of informal norms, which could vary significantly across courses or even between individual teachers.

> *"It depends on the teacher. One might say you can use it to get ideas, another won't say anything at all, so you just don't mention it." Student 3*

Teachers echoed these concerns, acknowledging that institutional communication on AI use had been vague or delayed. While some teachers had begun to develop their informal approaches, others expressed discomfort in navigating such a complex issue without proper support.

> *"We haven't really received any formal training or clear policy. Everyone's kind of figuring it out on their own, which makes it hard to know where to draw the line." Teacher 2*

This lack of clarity also affected how teachers responded to suspected AI use. Some noted that while they could sometimes sense when a text had been generated by a tool like ChatGPT, they felt reluctant to act without institutional backing.

> *"I've seen work that I'm fairly sure is AI-generated, but I can't prove it. And without a policy, it's hard to know what to do." Teacher 5*

The shared experience of uncertainty highlights the need for universities to develop consistent and transparent policies and offer professional development to help staff and students navigate emerging technologies. Until then, many participants expect informal norms and personal judgment to continue shaping academic practice.

4.4 AI and learning behaviour

Participants reflected on how generative AI positively and negatively affects their learning. Some viewed AI as a valuable tool for clarifying thoughts or getting unstuck. Others emphasised the risk of relying too much on AI and bypassing important parts of the learning process.

> *"I think it makes you learn worse because you don't really have to think for yourself. You get an answer, and then you maybe don't even think about why that answer came up." Student 2*

Several students mentioned that using AI can make assignments easier but less meaningful. The convenience of getting quick feedback or explanations was acknowledged, but some worried that it might reduce long-term understanding or critical thinking.

> *"It definitely helps when I'm stuck or need to formulate something better, but sometimes I think I just take the easy way out." Student 6*

Others appreciated how AI helped them gain new perspectives or reflect on their writing as long as it was used consciously.

"It helps me compare how I wrote it with how ChatGPT would write it, and that makes me reflect on what I might improve." Student 4

A few teachers noted that AI might shift how students approach tasks, often with less depth. They observed that students sometimes skip reading material and rely too heavily on AI to summarise or answer questions.

"It changes how students read. I've seen examples where they just ask ChatGPT instead of reading the course text." Teacher 2

The findings indicate a changing learning environment where AI tools support and disrupt traditional academic practices. The challenge lies in developing habits that preserve depth, independence, and reflection in an increasingly AI-mediated space.

4.5 Ethical uncertainty and shifting responsibility

Both students and teachers expressed concern about the ethical implications of using generative AI tools in academic work. While the tools were seen as helpful for brainstorming or structuring ideas, participants also questioned where to draw the line between acceptable use and misuse.

Students frequently described an internal struggle when using AI for writing. They acknowledged that relying too heavily on the tool could result in a product that no longer felt like theirs.

"Sometimes I've felt a bit guilty. Like, I know I've used it too much and I don't know if what I submitted was really mine anymore" Student 3

This tension was described as a personal judgment call. Some felt that using AI early in the writing process was riskier than using it for polishing language or rewording ideas. Others spoke about trying to balance support with effort.

"I use it to get ideas or check my wording, but I always rewrite everything. Otherwise, it doesn't feel like I've done the work" Student 4

Students also described how situational factors, such as stress or deadlines, influenced their AI use.

"When I'm short on time, I'm more likely to let it do more of the work. But afterwards, I feel unsure if that was okay" Student 2

Teachers shared similar concerns, especially about the potential for AI tools to reduce independent thinking.

"The tool itself isn't unethical, but how it's used can be. If students aren't learning or thinking for themselves, then we've lost something essential" Teacher 3

Several teachers said they struggled to determine when students had crossed the line into inappropriate use, especially when AI use was not disclosed. This lack of visibility made maintaining consistent expectations across courses and classrooms challenging.

> *"Some students are open about using it, others hide it. It's hard to set a standard when we don't really know how it's being used" Teacher 1*

Both groups described current ethical norms as vague and improvised. Students said they often relied on their judgment or informal discussions with peers.

> *"We just talk to each other, like 'how much are you using it?' because the university hasn't really said much" Student 5*

Meanwhile, teachers wanted clearer institutional support to help them guide students more effectively.

> *"Right now, we're relying a lot on students' own judgement. But not everyone has the same understanding of where the line is" Teacher 1*

The common picture that emerged was uncertainty. Ethical decisions were often made individually, without shared standards. Participants called for more explicit guidance from universities to clarify expectations and prevent unintentional misuse.

4.6 Anticipating a future with AI in education

Participants across roles acknowledged that generative AI tools will likely remain a permanent feature of higher education. Rather than resisting this development, many called for proactive strategies to help students and educators navigate its presence responsibly.
Students commonly viewed AI as something that would inevitably become integrated into academic life. Several expressed a desire for more structured guidance, suggesting universities should lead in teaching appropriate and ethical use.

> *"It feels like AI is going to be part of everything. So instead of banning it, I think schools need to show us how to use it properly" Student 2*

Teachers, while sometimes more cautious, echoed this view. Some had already introduced AI-based tasks in their courses, such as critical evaluation of AI-generated texts, to foster digital literacy. At the same time, concerns were raised about the rapid adoption of AI tools without sufficient institutional reflection.

> *"It feels like we're rushing into using AI just to keep up. But we haven't really stopped to ask what kind of education we want in the long run" Teacher 2*

There were also concerns that overreliance on AI could eventually erode essential academic skills. Participants questioned what learning might mean in a context where tools can automate key parts of the thinking process.

“If everyone starts using it for everything, then what’s the point of learning to write or think deeply yourself?” Student 1

While caution was present, the general sentiment was not rejection but careful optimism. Participants saw the potential for AI to support learning but emphasised the need for universities to define clear boundaries, expectations, and pedagogical strategies that would guide its integration in meaningful and responsible ways.

4.7 Summary of empirical findings

The empirical findings in this thesis highlight key tensions, reflections, and opportunities associated with using generative AI tools in higher education. Through thematic analysis of interviews with students and teachers, six overarching themes were identified, each capturing distinct but interconnected aspects of how AI influences perceptions of academic integrity, learning practices, and institutional response. These themes reveal a landscape where students and teachers navigate new boundaries of responsibility, authorship, and educational norms, often without clear guidance. While generative AI is viewed as a helpful tool, it also raises questions about fairness, ethics, and the future of assessment.

The table below summarises the key findings from the empirical material, presenting a condensed overview of each theme and illustrative quotes that reflect participants’ experiences and concerns. While the content in the table does not introduce new findings beyond what is presented in the primary analysis, it supports transparency. It provides a clear overview of how each theme is grounded in the data.

Theme	Key insight	Illustrative quote
Navigating responsible AI use	AI tools are mainly used for structure, brainstorming, or inspiration. Clear personal boundaries help prevent overuse and preserve learning.	*“I try not to use it for writing the actual content. It’s more like a structure tool or to help me get started.”* Student 4
Perceptions of academic integrity in the AI era	Generative AI challenges definitions of originality and ownership. Using it too heavily can feel like overstepping an ethical line.	*“Sometimes I’ve felt a bit guilty. Like, I know I’ve used it too much and I don’t know if what I submitted was really mine anymore.”* Student 3

Institutional uncertainty and informal norms	Universities lack clear and consistent policies on AI use. Students and teachers navigate expectations informally or on a case-by-case basis.	*"There's nothing written anywhere that says what's okay or not. Some teachers are chill with it, and others are not."* Student 1
AI and learning behaviour	AI is reshaping study habits and assignment design. There is growing pressure to rethink assessment formats to maintain integrity.	*"The way we assess needs to change. If students can do it with ChatGPT, maybe we're asking the wrong questions."* Teacher 2
Ethical uncertainty and shifting responsibility	Ethical boundaries around AI use are often unclear. Students and teachers are left to define responsible use without shared norms.	*"The tool itself isn't unethical, but how it's used can be. If students aren't learning or thinking for themselves, then we've lost something essential."* Teacher 3
Anticipating a future with AI in education	AI is seen as inevitable in academic settings. Clearer strategies, shared rules, and thoughtful integration are needed moving forward.	*"We need to find a middle ground. Banning it is unrealistic, but using it without rules is risky."* Teacher 4

Table 3: Summary of empirical findings from student and teacher interviews

The themes and insights summarised in the table above serve as a foundation for the following discussion. The next chapter builds on these empirical findings to revisit the research question and connect participants' experiences to the broader literature on academic integrity, ethics, and AI in higher education. The aim is to reflect on how these perspectives can inform future practice and guide institutions, students, and educators in navigating the challenges introduced by generative AI tools.

5 Discussion

This study explores how students and teachers in Swedish higher education perceive the use of AI-based text-generation tools, with a particular focus on academic integrity. Through a concept-driven literature review and thematic analysis of interviews, the thesis aimed to understand how such tools are used in practice, how they influence perceptions of authorship and plagiarism, and how students and teachers navigate emerging ethical and institutional uncertainties. The research question guiding the work was: How do students and teachers in Swedish universities perceive the impact of AI-based text generation tools on academic integrity, particularly in relation to plagiarism and ethical practices?

The findings revealed a landscape in transition. Participants expressed interest and caution, often highlighting the practical value of AI tools while acknowledging the ethical tensions and blurred boundaries they introduce. In many cases, students and teachers were left to interpret acceptable use independently, guided more by informal norms than formal policy. These perspectives were organised into six themes, reflecting shared concerns and differing experiences across roles and academic disciplines.

This chapter discusses each theme concerning the literature reviewed in Chapter 2. The aim is to interpret the findings through the lens of existing research, examine how the data support or challenge current understanding, and consider what the participants' experiences suggest for future academic practice and institutional development.

5.1 Navigating responsible AI use

Participants across faculties described a growing familiarity with AI-based text generation tools, with ChatGPT being the most prominent. While the tool was often viewed as helpful, its use was framed by a careful balancing act. Students repeatedly emphasised that their intent was not to replace their thinking but to support it. They highlighted use cases such as generating structure, clarifying phrasing, or breaking through writer's block. This cautious but exploratory approach reflects the ambivalence found in Söderström et al. (2024), where educators recognised the potential of such tools but warned against losing the reflective depth that traditional writing processes require.

What became apparent was that students had developed informal boundaries around what constitutes responsible use. These were not imposed externally but rather emerged from a sense of academic conscience. For some, using AI to generate a whole paragraph felt like "too much," even if the result was technically original. This echoes the observations of Schlagwein and Willcocks (2023), who argue that AI-assisted writing creates a new grey area where traditional measures of academic effort no longer apply. Börekci and Çelik (2024) similarly highlight how digital literacy and internalised norms shape student choices, suggesting that ethical awareness influences responsible use as much as it is by institutional policy**.**
Teachers also acknowledged this line, but with slightly different concerns. They questioned how far students should be allowed to rely on automated tools before the learning experience is diluted. Kamalov et al. (2023) and Farrokhnia et al. (2023) both warn that AI's convenience reduces the development of key academic skills, particularly critical thinking and independent analysis. Some students seemed aware of this risk, describing the temptation to overuse AI during stress or fatigue, which they viewed as a shortcut rather than a sustainable practice.

Importantly, this suggests that students and teachers try adapting to a context where norms are no longer self-evident. Personal judgment becomes the default without institutional clarity, but this can vary widely between individuals. The literature supports the view that clear guidance is essential to preventing misuse while preserving the pedagogical benefits of these tools (Miao et al., 2021; Dempere et al., 2023). The underlying insight here is that responsible AI use is not just a technical question but a moral and pedagogical one. While participants mainly favoured cautious experimentation, they also signalled a strong desire for institutions to lead in defining realistic and ethically grounded boundaries. Floridi and Chiriatti (2020) add that the outputs of generative AI lack actual authorship or understanding, and this limitation challenges how we frame moral responsibility when students submit AI-assisted work as their own.

5.2 Perceptions of academic integrity in the AI era

Academic integrity remains one of the most contested aspects of AI integration in education. Across the interviews, participants raised concerns beyond traditional definitions of plagiarism. While some recognised that generative AI can produce unique content that avoids direct copying, they questioned whether this should qualify as original work. These views support the concerns raised by Meyer et al. (2023), who argue that current definitions of plagiarism are insufficient for assessing AI-generated content. Smutny and Schreiberova (2020) further suggest that when students use AI-generated content without fully understanding its origin or accuracy, the traditional link between authorship and accountability becomes unstable.

Students expressed anxiety over authorship and contribution. Several noted that while the final submission might not have copied any specific source, it did not fully represent their thinking if the tool had contributed significantly. Schlagwein and Willcocks (2023) argue that academic integrity is rooted in originality and the learner's intellectual ownership, a concern echoed in participant reflections. This tension illustrates how generative AI challenges foundational academic values, creating uncertainty around what should be disclosed and what level of assistance is acceptable.
Teachers, on the other hand, often framed these concerns around assessment. If AI-generated content cannot be clearly distinguished from student-authored work, it becomes difficult to evaluate learning outcomes reliably. Dempere et al. (2023) note that many institutions are struggling to update their integrity frameworks fast enough to keep up with the pace of technological change. Dwivedi et al. (2023) similarly highlight that academic institutions face urgent pressure to adopt policies that preserve trust while acknowledging AI's permanent presence in educational contexts. This lag creates practical problems for educators who must make case-by-case decisions without formal guidance. Despite this, both groups agreed on the importance of transparency. Students expressed a willingness to disclose their use of AI if asked, and teachers often saw disclosure as a critical step toward maintaining trust in academic work. Evangelista (2025) suggests that disclosure should become a norm rather than an exception, especially as AI tools become more embedded in everyday learning.

This reveals an evolving understanding of integrity that cannot be resolved through policy alone. Participants acknowledged that the individual's ethical weight remains even if institutions offer rules. The literature highlights that meaningful integrity in AI will require cultural change and pedagogical adaptation (Lo, 2023; Miao et al., 2021). Perceptions of academic integrity are shifting in response to AI, and the tension between support and substitution is central to that shift. What emerges is a need for updated frameworks that respect the realities of tool-assisted learning while still affirming the value of independent thought and intellectual honesty.

5.3 Institutional uncertainty and informal norms

The lack of consistent institutional guidance on using AI-based tools was a recurring issue across the interviews. Both students and teachers described a climate of uncertainty, where individual interpretations of what is allowed had replaced formalised standards. This aligns with findings by Söderström et al. (2024), who note that universities have struggled to keep pace with AI developments, leaving staff and students to navigate a complex and rapidly shifting ethical landscape mainly on their own. López-Pérez et al. (2023) observe that while institutions increasingly recognise the impact of generative AI, many lack implementation strategies that translate policy intentions into practical support.

Students often relied on informal signals from teachers or peers to determine whether AI use was acceptable. Without clear policies, decisions about "too much" were negotiated depending on the course, the assignment, or the person grading the work. This inconsistency led to confusion and a sense of risk, especially when students were uncertain whether their actions would be judged fairly. These concerns echo Dempere et al. (2023), who stress that the lack of shared institutional norms undermines transparency and can foster unequal treatment across different academic contexts. Teachers also expressed frustration with the lack of clear direction. While some had taken proactive steps to address AI use in their teaching, such as adding disclaimers to their syllabus or modifying assignments, others admitted they were unsure what guidance to follow. Evangelista (2025) discusses how many institutions are still developing policies, often through internal working groups or pilot projects, but until those are implemented, teachers must rely on personal judgment. Ogunleye et al. (2024) argue that to build confidence and coherence in AI integration, universities must invest in policy development and professional training that equip educators to respond to the evolving landscape.

The variability in institutional responses also complicates academic integrity enforcement. Without a shared definition of responsible AI use, educators face difficulty applying consistent assessment criteria, and students are left guessing where the line is drawn. Miao et al. (2021) argue that effective AI governance in education requires institutions to go beyond policy and build capacity for ethical reasoning among staff and students. This points to a broader governance gap. Participants were not necessarily opposed to AI tools but lacked the policy, support, and training infrastructure to use them confidently and responsibly. Uncertainty becomes the norm in this vacuum, and informal workarounds replace structured approaches. Bridging this gap will be essential if universities are to foster ethical, equitable, and future-ready learning environments.

5.4 AI and learning behaviour

AI-based tools reshape writing practices and influence how students approach learning more broadly. Participants described how tools like ChatGPT have changed their habits, including brainstorming, structuring ideas, and engaging with written feedback. For many, the tool had become a new kind of "thinking partner," helping to clarify complex thoughts or generate alternative ways of expressing ideas. This corresponds to the findings by Chen et al. (2020), who noted that AI tools can enhance metacognitive learning by providing real-time support. Hasan et al. (2020) also found that AI-assisted platforms can support students in navigating complex tasks more effectively, especially when embedded into high-stakes or deadline-driven learning environments.

This transformation is not without its drawbacks. Several students expressed concern that frequent use of AI tools may encourage superficial engagement with course material. Instead of grappling with complex concepts or struggling through first drafts, students might be tempted to use AI as a shortcut. Farrokhnia et al. (2023) warn that such overreliance can hinder deeper learning and reduce opportunities for critical thinking. Participants in the study recognised this risk, often qualifying their use of AI as helpful only "in moderation." Bobula (2024) cautions that while AI may boost short-term productivity, its long-term impact on critical thinking, intellectual independence, and reflective learning remains a significant concern in higher education.

Teachers also discussed adapting their assessment strategies in light of these shifts. Some were rethinking assignment formats to make them less susceptible to AI use, for example, by emphasising oral presentations or in-class writing. Evangelista (2025) reports similar trends in international institutions, where educators experiment with formats that encourage authentic, reflective, and interactive learning. These changes aim not only to preserve academic integrity but also to foster more meaningful student engagement. Another point raised was how AI influences time management and productivity. Students reported feeling more efficient when using AI, particularly during high-pressure situations. While this can be a benefit, it also raises concerns about dependency. As Kamalov et al. (2023) noted, integrating AI into everyday academic routines may unintentionally devalue the formative struggles central to learning.
This suggests that AI's influence extends beyond individual assignments to broader educational practices. The challenge is not whether AI has a place in learning but how to ensure that its use aligns with pedagogical goals. As Söderström et al. (2024) highlight, the future of education will depend on how institutions balance innovation with integrity, ensuring that technological tools support rather than replace the human aspects of academic development.

5.5 Ethical uncertainty and shifting responsibility

The interviews revealed significant ethical ambiguity surrounding the use of generative AI in academic work. Participants across roles described situations where they were unsure whether their use of tools like ChatGPT crossed a line. For students, ethical responsibility was often tied to how much the tool contributed to the final product. If AI-generated output dominated the early drafting stages or heavily influenced the final formulation, participants expressed discomfort, even when no formal rule had been broken. This aligns with Schlagwein and Willcocks (2023), who argue that the emergence of generative AI has blurred traditional notions of authorship and originality. Floridi and Chiriatti (2020) further argue that AI-generated text lacks intentionality or understanding, complicating the ethical assessment of student work that appears polished but may be disconnected from genuine intellectual effort.

Some students admitted feeling guilty after relying on AI too much, particularly under time constraints. This emotional response reflects a deeper uncertainty about where individual effort ends and machine assistance begins. As Meyer et al. (2023) discuss, this ambiguity can undermine the sense of ownership over academic work, challenging conventional definitions of plagiarism even when the text is not copied from a human source.
Teachers echoed these concerns but framed them regarding cognitive engagement and learning outcomes. Several worried that the increasing ease of generating polished text could encourage students to avoid the more demanding and formative aspects of academic work. In their view, responsible use requires more than disclosure; it requires students to reflect critically on when and why to use the tool. This distinction is also reflected in Dempere et al. (2023), who argue that AI use in education should be grounded in clear pedagogical and ethical rationale. Dwivedi et al. (2023) add that without well-developed institutional frameworks, responsibility falls unevenly on individuals, creating inconsistent expectations and potential inequities in enforcement.

A further complication is that ethical norms remain informal and situational. While students described acting “responsibly” according to their standards, there was little shared understanding of what that meant in practice. Teachers lacked a common framework for evaluating appropriate use, often defaulting to individual judgment. As Evangelista (2025) points out, this absence of collective norms makes it challenging to ensure fairness, particularly when students' experiences and access to AI tools differ. Some participants raised questions about equity, such as how AI might affect students with different language backgrounds. This was not a dominant theme. Instead, the broader concern was that responsibility for ethical conduct had been shifted to individuals without sufficient support. As Söderström et al. (2024) suggest, institutions must be more active in shaping ethical engagement with AI rather than leaving it to chance or improvisation. In this context, many participants called for obvious ethical guidance from universities. Rather than banning AI outright, they wanted to support learning how to use it meaningfully and appropriately. This reflects a growing consensus in the literature (Miao et al., 2021; Lo, 2023) that AI literacy must include ethical competence, not just technical familiarity.

5.6 Anticipating a future with AI in education

Participants consistently recognised that generative AI will remain a permanent feature of academic life. There was a widespread sense that tools like ChatGPT are “here to stay.” The question is no longer whether they should be used but how they should be integrated. Both students and teachers expressed hope that institutions would take a more proactive role in guiding this process. This mirrors the conclusions of Miao et al. (2021), who argue that the effective integration of AI into education requires transparent strategies, inclusive policies, and pedagogical innovation. Smutny and Schreiberova (2020) similarly argue that once digital tools become embedded in learning cultures, ignoring them is no longer viable as institutions must adapt their practices, expectations, and pedagogies accordingly.
A recurring sentiment was the need for balance. Students wanted the freedom to use AI for support, but not at the cost of learning. They viewed AI as a tool that should enhance, not replace, academic effort. Teachers, in turn, sought ways to adapt their teaching and assessment without losing sight of core educational values. This dual concern for innovation and integrity reflects what Dempere et al. (2023) describe as a key challenge of AI adoption in higher education.

Participants also identified the need for long-term thinking. While some institutions had introduced temporary guidelines or restrictions, many interviewees believed that a more sustainable approach was needed, a strategy that accounts for evolving technologies and diverse learning contexts. Evangelista (2025) argues that AI policy must be dynamic and informed by continuous feedback from students, educators, and researchers. The interview data in this study strongly support that position. Ogunleye et al. (2024) advocate for evolving governance models that blend policy development with ongoing educator support and student engagement. Interestingly, both students and teachers suggested that shared frameworks and co-created guidelines could help bridge the gap between institutional rules and everyday academic practice. Rather than imposing top-down policies, participants favoured collaborative efforts that acknowledge the lived experiences of those using the tools. This resonates with Lo (2023), who emphasises participatory approaches to AI governance in education.

The discussion about AI ultimately underscores a forward-looking orientation. Participants were not calling for strict control or open-ended freedom but thoughtful integration grounded in clarity, fairness, and shared responsibility. As Söderström et al. (2024) note, this requires a shift from reactive to strategic responses and policing AI to enable informed and ethical engagement.

6 Conclusion

This thesis explored how students and teachers in Swedish higher education perceive the impact of AI-based text generation tools on academic integrity, with a particular focus on plagiarism and ethical practices. In response to the widespread adoption of generative AI tools such as ChatGPT, the study combined a concept-driven literature review with qualitative insights from semi-structured interviews across several faculties. The aim was to understand how these tools are experienced in practice, how they influence ideas of authorship and responsibility, and how institutions might respond to the ethical and pedagogical challenges they present.

The findings show that while students and teachers acknowledge the usefulness of generative AI, they also encounter uncertainty about using these tools responsibly. Both groups emphasised the importance of personal judgement and transparency, often navigating these questions without consistent institutional guidance. AI was commonly used to support thinking, clarify ideas, and structure academic writing, yet concerns remained about the risk of undermining learning and blurring the boundaries of academic integrity. Six themes were identified: navigating responsible AI use, perceptions of academic integrity in the AI era, institutional uncertainty and informal norms, AI and learning behaviour, ethical uncertainty and shifting responsibility, and anticipating a future with AI in education.

Together, these themes reflect a higher education environment in transition, where AI tools are increasingly used in everyday academic practice despite limited formal support or shared norms. A summary of these empirical findings is presented in Table 3.

This thesis contributes to the existing literature by offering a grounded account of how academic communities in Sweden are engaging with generative AI. It supports concerns raised by earlier research (e.g., Dempere et al., 2023; Evangelista, 2025; Miao et al., 2021) while also pointing to the importance of local, context-aware strategies that align with the needs of both students and teachers. The findings may inform the development of institutional policies, ethical frameworks, and teaching practices better suited to AI-enhanced education realities. As with any qualitative study, this research has limitations. The small sample size and interview-based design limit the generalisation of findings across all institutions. The study focused on perceptions rather than observed behaviour, and their academic and disciplinary context shaped each participant's experience. Recruitment of student participants proved more difficult than anticipated, which may have influenced the balance of perspectives in the data. These limitations suggest further research involving more extensive and diverse samples and follow-up studies examining how institutional responses continue to evolve.

This thesis highlights the urgency of treating generative AI as a technical development and a broader educational shift. While students and teachers are already adapting to these tools, institutions now face the task of responding in thoughtful, ethical, and inclusive ways. The challenge is not simply to manage AI use but to ensure that it strengthens rather than weakens the integrity and purpose of higher education.

While this study is situated in the Swedish higher education system, the findings may also be relevant to universities in other countries facing similar challenges around academic integrity, authorship, and responsible AI use. Future research could explore how perceptions differ across academic disciplines or evolve as institutional policies become more clearly defined and widely implemented. Universities can already begin to act on the insights presented. Teachers may benefit from precise course-level guidance on using AI; administrators could support policy development through cross-faculty collaboration; and students should be included in defining what responsible AI usage means in their contexts. These steps may help reduce uncertainty, promote trust, and ensure that AI becomes a tool for learning, rather than a threat to it.

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Appendix

Appendix 1: Interview guide

Introduction

Hello, and thank you for agreeing to participate in this interview. My name is Johan Lorentz, and I am conducting this research as part of my master's thesis at Halmstad Högskolan/University. The study aims to explore how students and teachers in Swedish higher education perceive and experience the use of AI-based text generation tools such as ChatGPT, particularly concerning academic integrity.

Remember that participation is voluntary, and you can withdraw anytime without explanation. The interview will be audio recorded for transcription and analysis purposes, but your identity will remain anonymous, and no personal information will be linked to your responses.

I will be using a list of guiding questions during our conversation, but please feel free to speak freely, and we may follow up on things that come up naturally. If any question feels unclear or uncomfortable, you can skip it.

1. General background

- Can you describe your role as a [student/teacher] at [university name]?
- What subject area are you currently involved in?
- In what ways have you come across AI-based text generation tools (e.g., ChatGPT) in your academic or teaching work?

2. Use of AI-based text generation tools

- Could you describe how you have used, or seen others use, tools like ChatGPT in academic contexts?
- Can you imagine situations where such tools were handy, challenging, or unexpected?

3. Perceptions of academic integrity

- How do you understand academic integrity in your current studies/teaching?
- In your view, how does using AI tools relate to academic integrity?
- Are there situations where you feel using AI tools might raise questions around originality or authorship?

4. Institutional rules and support

- Are you aware of any guidance, policies, or discussions at [your university] about using AI tools in education?

- Have you received any support or communication that helped you understand how these tools should or should not be used?

5. Learning and assessment impact

- In your experience, how (if at all) have AI tools affected how students learn or how academic work is assessed?
- Have you adjusted how you study / design assignments / assess work due to these tools?

6. Broader ethical concerns and future perspectives

- What opportunities or concerns do you associate with AI text generation tools in education?
- How do you see these tools fitting into higher education in the future?
- Are there any values or principles you think should guide their use?

7. Ending

- Is there anything we have not discussed that you feel is important to mention?
- Do you have any questions about the study or how your input will be used?

Appendix 2: Participant information sheet

Participant Information Sheet
Master's thesis in Digital Service Innovation
Halmstad University

Project title:
AI and academic integrity: The impact of students' reliance on AI-based text generation tools in Swedish universities

Researcher:
Johan Lorentz
Master's student, Digital Service Innovation
Halmstad University

Purpose of the study
This study is part of a master's thesis conducted at Halmstad University. The aim is to explore how Swedish higher education students and teachers perceive and experience using AI-based text generation tools like ChatGPT. The focus is on academic integrity, including issues related to plagiarism and ethical practices.

Participation and interview process
You are invited to participate in an individual interview lasting approximately 30 to 45 minutes. The interview will be semi-structured and based on a guide developed from earlier research. You will be asked to share your thoughts, experiences, and reflections on AI tools used in academic contexts.

Participation is entirely voluntary. You may decline to answer any question or withdraw from the interview at any point, without giving a reason. There are no right or wrong answers. The purpose is to understand your personal view.

Confidentiality and data handling
With your permission, the interview will be audio recorded and later transcribed for analysis. Your identity will be kept anonymous. No names or identifiable details will appear in the thesis or any presentation of the findings. All recordings and transcripts will be securely stored and permanently deleted after the completion of the thesis. The data will be used solely for academic purposes.

Contact
If you have any questions about the study, please feel free to contact:
Johan Lorentz
Master's student, Digital Service Innovation
Halmstad University
johan.lorentz@gmail.com

Appendix 3: Consent form

Consent Form
Master's thesis in Digital Service Innovation
Halmstad University

Project title:
AI and academic integrity: The impact of students' reliance on AI-based text generation tools in Swedish universities

Researcher:
Johan Lorentz
Master's student, Digital Service Innovation
Halmstad University

Please read the statements below and confirm your agreement by ticking the box and signing at the end.

☐ I have read and understood the information provided in the Participant Information Sheet.

☐ I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I may withdraw at any time without giving a reason.

☐ I agree that the interview should be audio recorded for transcription and analysis.

☐ I understand that my responses will be kept anonymous and that no identifying information will be used in the thesis or any related material.

☐ I consent to the data collected in this interview being used for this master's thesis and related academic purposes.

Participant name: ____________________________________

Signature: ____

Date: __________________